Illustration Design System

Keizersgracht Media | Version 3.1

00 GUIDING PRINCIPLE

These guidelines are a compass, not a rulebook. Every illustration should tell a clear story that lets a website visitor understand a project's real-world impact in about three seconds. Change the layout, the number of nodes, or the structure (including the 3-act format) whenever a project needs it. Start every new illustration from its own brief and treat everything below as reference, not as the answer.

01 FINDING THE RIGHT LEVEL OF ABSTRACTION

- **Too literal.** Don't put dense paragraphs or full app screenshots inside cards. It overwhelms the eye and makes the section hard to glance at.
- **Too vague.** Don't rely on unlabeled skeleton lines or made-up technical jargon and metrics. Visitors shouldn't have to guess what the software does.
- **The sweet spot.** Combine simple visual elements (stepped graphs, progress blocks, checklists) with one short, real-world sentence or question. If the text is generated, cut it off with "..." before it gets into detail.

Core rules

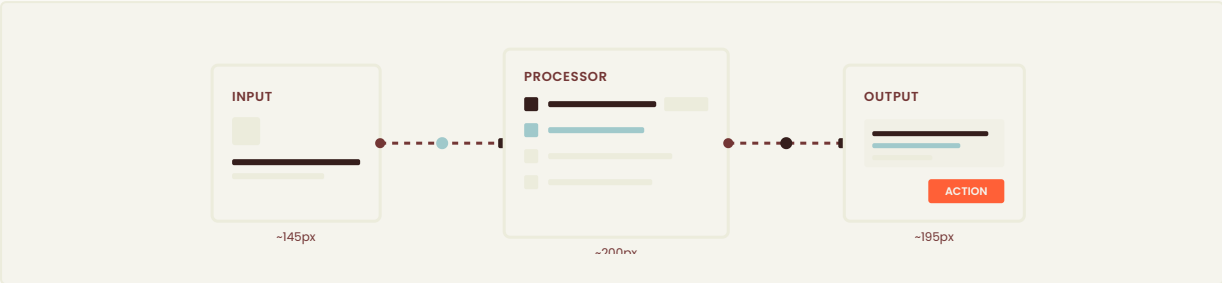
- **Floating canvas.** Illustrations sit on a transparent container with no outer box, so cards and connectors float directly on the page background.
- **No cartoon people.** Show human actors (field teams, operations staff, institutions) through the tools they use or the screens they look at.
- **Center-heavy silhouette.** Outer cards stay compact and the middle card is slightly larger, which gives the layout a gentle rhythm.
- **Canvas and sizing.** Desktop uses a standard 960×480 frame (centerline y = 240) that unwraps into a vertical stack on mobile. Always size cards with enough breathing room so text and elements never press against borders.

02 TWO EXAMPLES FOR REFERENCE

These are examples, not templates, and not the end product you should aim for. For every new illustration, read the brief first: what does the project do, who is looking, and what should they understand? Then choose the structure that tells that story best. That could be one of these, a mix, or something quite different (more cards, fewer, another flow). Placeholder content is used below.

Example A: Linear pipeline

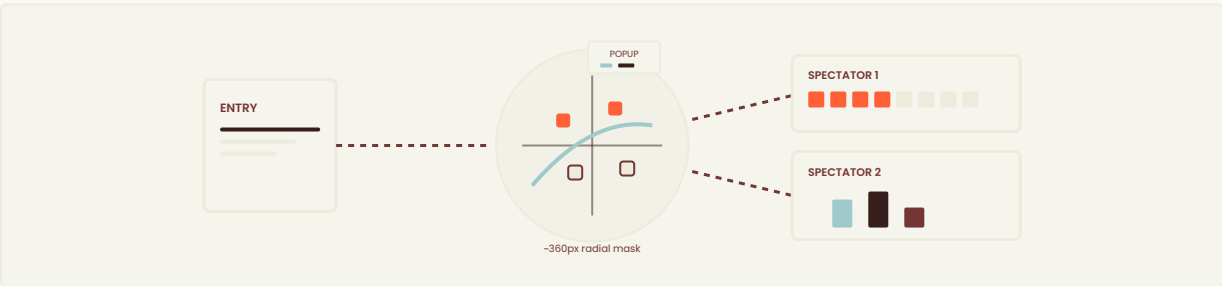
Fits workflows where something comes in, gets processed, and produces a result (intake, routing, automated drafting).



- **Card 1, Input (~145px):** cycles through three states of the same kind of input, each showing a short example such as "Example question?" Keep transitions fresh—whether using a crisp vertical flip, slide, or fade.
- **Card 2, Processor (~200px):** a 4-row checklist with 10x10px checkboxes (2px radius). Row 1 stays checked in every state. Rows 2 to 4 switch on and off in sync with Card 1.
- **Card 3, Output (~195px):** types out a one-sentence reply that matches the input, cuts off with "..." (for example "Thanks for getting in touch, here is what we can do..."), then pulses the coral action button.
- **Connectors:** Keep the signal transfer clearly visible to the spectator (a well-defined traveling pulse or terminal ping) so people can easily track cause and effect without straining to see it.

Example B: Hub-and-spoke map

Fits field data collection, geographic networks, and reporting to several stakeholders.



- **Act 1, Entry card (~140px):** a small card with a simple icon and a 3-row abstract checklist, connected to the map by a dashed line.
- **Act 2, Map hub (~360px circle):** a simplified map (1px Espresso streets, an Aqua water line, building footprints) inside a radial fade mask: `radial-gradient(circle, #000 48%, transparent 72%)`. Four clickable squares (2px radius) turn Coral one by one. The active square opens a floating popup with a small stepped sparkline or bar chart, with no numbers.
- **Act 3, Two spectator cards:** the top card shows a row of 8 squares that turn Coral as items join, with a one-line caption. The bottom card shows 3 bars (Aqua and Espresso) that change height as the map advances, also with a one-line caption.

03 COLOR TOKENS AND CORNER RADII

Token	Hex	Used for
Canvas	`#F5F4ED`	Page background, card fill, floating popups
Sand	`#ECECDC`	Card borders (1.5px), unvisited map nodes, empty chart tracks, subtle bubbles
Espresso	`#351E1C`	Titles (Sintony Bold, 13 to 14px), icons, active checkboxes, main chart bars, map grid (1px)
Terracotta	`#733635`	Captions and micro-labels (Poppins, 11px), dashed connectors (1.5px, dash 3 3)
Aqua	`#A0C9CB`	Water vectors, stepped sparklines, secondary bars, active checklist highlights
Coral	`#FF6037`	Primary action buttons, active map pins, cumulative participation blocks

Corner radii

- **Cards:** 3px radius, with a warm shadow: `0 10px 24px rgba(115, 54, 53, 0.08)`
- **Checkboxes, buttons, map nodes, grid blocks:** 2px radius.
- **Skeleton and chart bars:** 1px radius.
- **Never use fully rounded pill shapes.**

04 ANIMATION AND TIMING

Animation is there to help the spectator follow the story. The timings further down come from the two examples and are only a starting point. For each new illustration, the question is whether a visitor can actually keep up.

What to check

- **Can they follow the process?** It should be clear what happens first, what it triggers, and where it ends up.
- **Is there time to take it in?** After something changes, give people a moment to look at each element before the next animation starts. More elements, text, or charts on screen means a longer pause.
- **Does it guide the eye?** Sequence the steps in reading or cause-and-effect order instead of changing everything at once, so attention moves in one direction.
- **Is there a rest before it loops?** Hold the finished state briefly before a new cycle begins, so the result can be read.
- **Does it hold up cold?** Watch it as a first-time visitor. If you lose track of what is happening, slow it down or simplify it.
- **Does it handle clicks cleanly?** Clicking any card or node should immediately jump to that state and smoothly restart the cycle. Avoid hover-pause locks that freeze the animation.

Cycle length

Set the length of a cycle per illustration, based on how much the spectator has to read and how many elements change. A single short line needs less time than a map with a popup and two charts. Both can be a repeating cycle, as long as the points above are met.

Timings used in the examples

Use as a reference for pacing, not as a rule.

Example A	About 7.5s per cycle: card 1 changes at 0.0s, connector pulse at 0.9s, card 2 updates at 1.5s, second connector pulse at 2.4s, card 3 types its reply from 3.0s to 6.0s, then the action button pulses.
Example B	One step every 6000ms, with already visited items staying marked so progress builds up.